The Start of a Legend

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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by n7punk

Summary

After being trained by Light Hope for years, Catra and Adora's home is discovered by Rebellion soldiers. Soon it becomes apparent that She-ra would have been revealed to the world today anyway.
(Or, the true start of Adora's destiny as planned by Light Hope)

Notes

This is part of an ongoing canon-divergent AU that is nonlinear but still wont make sense without reading at least the first fic for context. The TLDR is Light Hope raised Catra and Adora in the Whispering Woods with them knowing Adora's destiny was to be She-ra.

See the end of the work for more notes

Apparently Light Hope had a spider guardian factory this *whole damn time* and she just didn't tell them because she didn't want to waste resources turning it on when so far they could handle everything she needed a physical platform for. They're getting close to finally setting out to face the Horde themselves, though, and that means Light Hope will be alone and the Crystal Castle vulnerable. Well, vulnerable compared to before. The thing is basically a bunker. Catra isn't worried about it. The guardians make her more nervous than the idea of the place unattended, but at least they keep to the vents and out of sight. Light Hope's resources are finite and she hasn't made many. Yet.

Over the last few weeks, Light Hope has been kicking on the disused parts of the castle in preparation for Adora finally taking up the sword to lead the charge against the Horde. There are still a few dusty corridors that don't lead to anything and will likely never be turned on – for all Catra knows, they don't work anymore – but the sprawl of tunnels they once knew well feels like it has changed significantly. When Light Hope runs a cleaning protocol, they have to hang out on the surface for two hours so all the dust whipping around doesn't choke them.

When they get back, there's no break. They go right into training against one of the new spider guardians. When they finish *that*, Light Hope finally lets Catra go, but only Catra, because Adora has to continue training on the sword's additional powers. At this point, Adora can have her stupid magic destiny; Catra just wants a shower. If being normal gets her one of those, she isn't going to complain about it. At least, not today.

She's halfway through the bathroom door when a voice makes her jump so hard that she almost hits her head on the doorframe. The only thing that saves her is being short.

"Catra," Light Hope's voice says, causing Catra to whip around and gape at her. Light Hope is standing in the middle of their bedroom.

She shouldn't be able to project into this room. She shouldn't be able to do *anything*.

"You're not supposed to have sensors here," Catra blurts out. Light Hope *said* she didn't. They've said so much shit in this room. *Light Hope's a bore* and *I hate training, lets run away* and *Adora, you're… really pretty* in a tiny, hushed voice that clearly didn't convey what Catra wanted since Adora just smiled and said *aw, you are too*. Yeah, Catra wasn't *jealous*. Her heart is racing just thinking about all the things Light Hope could have heard that she thought were safe.

"Due to living beings' general desire for privacy," I do not listen to this room, but I still have the capability to. This urgent," Light Hope corrects. *Don't* and *can't* are so different that Catra's crisis isn't stopping, no matter how *urgent* Light Hope thinks it is- "Someone is trying to breach the castle entrance. You must go deal with the threat," Light Hope continues.

Oh. Fuck.

"Where's Adora?" Catra asks, already setting forward. Light Hope's projection follows her, flickering out momentarily when they cross out into the hidden hall that twists around the main chamber.

"She is coming up from the training deck, but she will hang back. My sensors have not picked up any approaching forces. I believe it is likely to be individuals attempting to explore. It would be for the best to drive them off without revealing the true nature of the castle or She-ra," Light Hope lists off. Catra growls under her breath as she leaps over the steps at the end of the hall and bursts out into the main entry. It's plausible – one time she and Adora stumbled onto a giant building in the woods and started exploring it only to find it was someone's house – but Adora could still help as *herself*. Plenty of people know about them.

Something is going on, but the only way Catra can find out what is to investigate. Besides, Light Hope is giving her an opportunity to do

something for herself – something *important* – without relying on Adora or her powers.

"Main entrance?" Catra verifies as she approaches it. The main chamber is accessed by a grand pathway that floats over a drop into darkness. It's convenient for an ambush, but if someone has made their way inside, they already have a problem.

"Yes," Light Hope confirms and Catra immediately turns and leaps down into the secret entrance's tunnel running beneath the main hall.

Light Hope doesn't follow her down. This might be the one place she *actually* can't project since it's outside of her control. They've never seen her here before, at least.

They never saw her in their bedroom, either.

Catra hits the button to unlock the override door. The door slides open and she slinks out, carefully stalking up the hidden ramp. She peeks over its edge just in time to watch a pair of humans *vanish* in a glow of pink from directly in front of the main door. She gapes, quickly glancing around, and then hears a voice made tinny by echoing coming out of the secret door behind her.

"What is this place?" It's a girl's voice. Great, fucking *teleportation*. Just perfect. Catra quickly slides back down the ramp and through the secret entrance before it can close behind her.

"I don't know, but it's remarkably well preserved for something so old. The writing on the door looked like it was from the First Ones," a boy's voice answers back. Catra follows the echoing, emerging beneath the entry hall with all the lights shut off. No light comes from the main chamber. Catra can't tell for sure if it's shut off from this angle, but she thinks so. If Light Hope had time to turn off the lights, she could probably shut the door too. Clearly she managed to power things down before they teleported in; once they saw the building reacting to them, they would know something is wrong.

The path stretches above Catra's head, hiding her from view as she listens to the footsteps and circles behind them. Silently, she climbs up one of the columns supporting the walkway on either side, looking down at the intruders.

A boy and a girl, both human, though the girl has magic. Her hair sparkles and in her hand she carries a small ball of light that isn't doing much to dismiss the shadows around them. Their clothes say they come from somewhere with wealth, probably Bright Moon considering Plumerian fashion is *distinct* and neither of them look like they're dressed for the cold of the Kingdom of Snows. At least it's not someone from the Horde.

Wait. Catra recognizes the girl's outline.

"There's airflow here. If there were some kind of damage to let it through from the surface, this place wouldn't look nearly this good after a thousand years. Maybe there's a climate control system still running that's helping preserve this place? It might explain the energy readings I'm picking up," the boy says, looking down at a digital pad in his hands. Oh, great, Light Hope's *spider production* or something has been picked up on sensors.

"Why would it have suddenly spiked? Something isn't right here, Bow. We need to investigate. If we don't find something, my mom's going to kill me for sneaking out," the girl says, only fueling Catra's theory. She has to remind herself that a lot of girls have moms, but she thinks there's probably a limited number of them who are interested in First One's artifacts.

Catra leaps to another column, following them as they move deeper. They completely miss the tiny crystals snapping beneath Catra's claws.

Maybe that's an idea. Catra smirks to herself as she thinks about how annoyed Light Hope will be and how this is likely to be the only time she's going to have an excuse for this. She braces herself for another launch, but this time she isn't careful. She digs her claws in

and scrapes them down the column as she leaps, making a horrific screech against the crystal surface. Both humans yell, whipping around and raising their light frantically as if that will magically make it reach the ceiling. Catra has already moved onto the next column, silently this time, as they squint up into the darkness.

"G-Glimmer , I don't think we're alone here," the boy – Bow , apparently – stammers. *There it is*. The princess of Bright Moon. Hopefully an ally rather than a threat, but that doesn't mean they want to give up their secret base location. Catra leaps, this time directly over their heads so she can cross to the other side of the entry. They catch a flash of the movement in the darkness, giving a very dignified – and very afraid – *wha!* as they desperately try to track her movements with the light. Catra has already curled around the back of the new column, her toe claws dug into the bottom of the decorative element where the column meets the ceiling.

She's strong, but she can't keep this up from too long. She's clinging onto a slippery surface with fingertips and claws. Taking a breath, she rattles out her most threatening growl, being met with a frightened *eep*. She peeks around the edge of the column. The humans have their sides pressed together, looking around desperately as Bow readies his weapon- a bow, really? Wow. Glimmer still has the light in one hand and is readying a fist with the other. Doesn't she have magic powers? This is kind of incredible.

"Glimmer , eyes!" Bow whispers, staring up at Catra. Glimmer frantically raises the light and gasps when she sees what Bow just did, startling back a little.

Right. Catra's eyes. The rest of her can be fully shrouded in shadow, but her eyes will still catch the light. It's a very different kind of glow than Adora's, but it's probably more threatening in the dark. She growls again and is surprised when it reverberates around the room much stronger than she can make it, the sound echoing from every corner like they're surrounded.

t' s *speakers*, Light Hope amplifying Catra's sounds, but it makes the human gasp and whip around regardless, back to back now. They must have trained together. They move in-sync, slowly circling and looking for a threat without ever parting to expose a vulnerability .

"W e're surrounded," Bow whispers frantically .

"Y eah, I hear it, Bow . What do you think they are?" Glimmer hisses back, annoyance her apparent response to anxiety . Well, that makes two of them. Catra rattles another growl in her chest. This time Light Hope must enhance it with some other recording because a hiss and a deep rattle underscores it. Both of the humans yelp again and Glimmer whips around, grabbing Bow's arm.

"Okay , time to get out of here!" she declares, and then they're gone in a shower of sparkles, an uncomfortable tinkling signaling their departure as the room goes black. Catra smirks to herself, loosening her grip on the column so she can slide down, her claws slowing her descent and making another horrible screech. She leaps down on the path gracefully as lights come on in the entry.

"Handled," Catra says to herself, straightening up onto her two feet again.

The sealed door into the main chamber begins to open for her, light spilling out. Catra turns to walk back in, but the door doesn't open more than a few inches. She frowns, approaching it.

"Whew , at least they're not in here," Bow' s voice echoes through the crack. Oh, come *on*.

Suddenly, a familiar *whoom* echoes from inside, doors coming slamming down, though the crack in front of her remains.

"Uh, that' s not good," Bow says again. Catra growls under her breath, stalking forward to look into the main entry. Bow and Glimmer are standing in the center, both at the ready to fight again with their gaze darting around.

The lights shut off.

"Oh, come on!" Glimmer yells, frustrated. Another ball of pink sparkles appears in her hand. Catra uses the cover of the relative darkness and their momentary distraction to slip in through the cracked door, darting around to one of the decorative juts up from the floor, climbing it so she can look down on the pair again.

"Hang on, let me try something," Glimmer mutters to her friend, pulling the ball of light close to her chest. Catra watches through narrowed eyes as Glimmer throws the ball up into the air. About halfway to the ceiling, to explodes in a sparkle of lights, causing Catra to flinch as her eyes are forced to harshly adjust. The sparkles hang in the air, pulsing a dull light into the room.

Catra blinks her eyes clear to find Bow looking around. His gaze lands on her and he freezes.

"Uh, Glimmer-" he starts to say , reaching back to grab her arm to draw her attention.

"You shouldnt be here," Catra growls out before Glimmer can even turn all the way around. Glimmer whips around, joining Bow in staring at her with wide eyes.

"What is *here*?" Bow asks, his voice weirdly genuine, questioning, something he shouldnt be to a monster lurking in the shadows.

That bit doesnt work so well when he can see that she's just a girl, though. Catra narrows her eyes at him.

"My *home*. Youre trespassing. Get out," she says. Glimmer squints up at her, seeming significantly less afraid now that she can see her. It's annoying. Catra still has the high ground, not to mention home turf advantage and *claws*. She has spent her entire life training against magic powers. Just because Glimmer has magic doesnt mean she can win. Catra could take her.

Don't fight the princess of Bright Moon, she reminds herself. One day soon you're going to want to be allies.

"And who are *you*? This is a First One's ruin. It doesn't belong to you. It's a historical landmark," Glimmer replies. *Don't fight the princess of Bright Moon no matter how hard she makes it*. Catra digs her claws into the crystal to keep herself still. Her ears twitch as she registers a quiet clunking and whirring that is starting to become familiar. Slowly, she grins, letting all her fangs show as the noise grows loud enough for Glimmer and Bow to hear it. Frantically, they look around.

The pink light might look ethereal in a different setting, but when it's illuminating three spider guardians crawling to their vent entrances around the room and looming over the chamber, ready to defend their home, it looks threatening, blue walls drenched like blood. Glimmer and Bow both freeze when they spot them, as if any movement will draw an attack.

"Tell that to the ruin," Catra responds. The guardians won't attack any more than she will, but Light Hope is helping her how she can without revealing the full truth. This castle is so much more than their home and training facility. It has the largest – and maybe only – databank of information on the She-ra and the First Ones. It's home to the planet-wide monitoring system. If it fell into the wrong hands, it could end the war – in a *bad* way. They need to keep knowledge of it as limited as possible.

"Who *are* you?" Glimmer responds, slowly turning her head to stare up at her. Bow watches Glimmer's back, ready for a surprise attack just like Catra and Adora do for each other, but she can see him keeping an eye on her in the corner of his eyes.

Catra's claws dig in again. The answer to that question is *no one*. She-ra's training partner? Adora's friend? Both meaningless to them, and secret. In the grand scheme of things, Catra is inconsequential. Eventually she'll be just one of hundreds to take up arms against the

Horde. The only thing that could set her apart is succeeding. She's no one, at least not yet. She's only here by chance and misfortune.

"The last of the magicats," Catra responds. It's what she can say, the one thing that defines her aside from Adora. Even that isn't untouched by her – she would be dead like the rest if it weren't for Adora's interference – but it's something she can say without anyone else knowing its tie to Adora. Catra watches Glimmer's eyes widen slightly and then she turns her head enough to exchange a glance with Bow.

"The magicat kingdom went dark in one night. They were near the Fright Zone. Everybody could guess what happened," Bow supplies for his friend. Apparently he's the smart one. Glimmer looks back to Catra, her face setting with determination.

"We're with the Rebellion. We fight the Horde. We're not a threat," she says.

There's a thud, distant, and then one of the guardians adjusts its leg, taking a few steps back into its tunnel like it slipped. The humans turn their heads to watch it nervously. They weren't looking at it before;they didn't see that it only moved after the thud, trying to cover the sound.

A sound that emanated from one of the back doors – the one blocking the passage down to the training deck.

What does Adora think she's doing?

"Then why are you breaking into my home? Just leave me alone," Catra returns, raising her voice and hoping Adora will maybe hear it through the door and realize Catra isn't in danger. The pair look back up to her.

"We're reading a huge power draw here. What are you doing?" Glimmer asks, her gaze suspicious. Catra growls under her breath. Truth is, Catra doesn't know;she just knows that Light Hope has

been kicking on the rest of the facility after conserving everything she could for eighteen years.

"I figured out how to power on new tunnels. It's just life support. Half this place has been covered in dust for years," Catra responds, because *I've been making spider robots* probably isn't going to go over well. She just needs to convince them to leave without realizing this is anything more than an old ruin with some defense measures.

"What about the others? The magicats?" Bow asks. Unlike Glimmer, he sounds hopeful. It takes Catra a moment to even remember the audio trick in the hallway.

"Echoing. It was just me," she responds, reluctantly, right as another loud thud echoes from the shut door.

"Catra!" Adora calls through before any of the guardians can try to cover for her again. It's muffled, but it makes the humans immediately turn around as Catra groans.

She leaps down from her perch, ignoring the way the humans whip to face her, an arrow trained on her as she circles the room and comes to stand in front of the door, glaring at it with her arms crossed. She isn't worried about showing the pair her back. She doesn't think they're actually going to shoot her and the spider guardians are still at the ready anyway.

"I'm *handling* it. Go back to playing with sharp objects," Catra hisses through the door. There's a pause. Just barely, Catra can tell Light Hope is speaking on the other side, though it's so quiet that she can't make words out and she's certain the humans can't tell it's happening in the middle of the room.

"Alone, huh?" Glimmer asks. She sounds gloating. Catra whips around, growling and flashing her fangs.

"This is *our* home. It's the one thing we have that the Horde didn't take. It isn't yours to traipse around in and pull apart for scrap," Catra

bites back, her heart beating too fast. Her claws are out, itching. She should be building alliances or something, probably, but she didn't know how much an intrusion like this would unsettle her. The castle is theirs. She doesn't want to give it up. She doesn't want these strangers to ruin what they have.

"Hey , we're not here to destroy anything! We're just following the signal," Bow tries to assure, lowering his arrow and raising his hands in surrender instead. His voice is warm and he's clearly trying to reason with her, but he has *not* met Catra. She hates being reasoned with.

"Well, you found it. You got your answer. Now get out. The ruin protects us, but it doesn't like *you*," Catra returns. Both of the humans flick their gaze to the door .

"How many of you survived?" Glimmer asks, voice a little hopeful. Catra's throat constricts.

One. Just one.

Before she can reply, she's interrupted by the awful screech of the crystal behind her. She whips around to find the Sword of Protection stabbed through the seam between the two doors. Before she can ask Adora what the *hell* she's doing, Adora leverages the sword, starting to force the doors open. They slide back seemingly voluntarily, Light Hope likely trying to prevent more damage. They open to reveal She-ra standing in the hall, her expression set.

"What are you *doing*? Why are you She-ra?" Catra hisses to Adora, her tail lashing. She was so close to talking the rebels down until Adora had to interrupt.

Adora barely glances at her, marching forward as the ruin stands down around them, lights flashing up, doors opening, and the spider guardians retreating back into their vents.

"The sensors picked up Horde chatter . Thaymor is under attack," Adora says. Catra freezes, her heart falling in her chest.

"*No*," she whispers. Adora stops, turning to give her a grim nod. Slowly, she turns looks towards where Glimmer and Bow are standing in the center of the ruin, staring at them. Their eyes are flicking between the now-visible mural of She-ra on the wall and Adora. Adora points at them.

"I don't know who you are, but we're going to defend the village, and you're coming with us. We can't leave you wandering in our home and we don't have time to waste," Adora says. She-ra's voice has a certain quality to it, either from magic or confidence, that makes it echo like a command. Catra runs forward to Adora's side, glaring down Glimmer and Bow from under Adora's arm. Glimmer and Bow get ahold of themselves to exchange a glance, coming to a decision in an instant together the same way Adora and Catra do.

"Thaymor is under the Rebellions' protection. It's our responsibility to defend it," Glimmer agrees. Catra rolls her eyes, but they don't have time to deal with grandstanding. She turns and heads for the entry hall. Adora follows, only needing to walk on her long legs to keep up with Catra's hesitant run, slowed to make sure the others follow her.

"Uh, who are you, though?" Glimmer asks as she and Bow move to follow them, trailing behind them. Adora doesn't look back, her grip tight on the sword in her hand.

"She-ra," she answers. They reach the entrance, the doors automatically opening for them as they approach. Light Hope has given up containing the situation, clearly.

"What's your stake in this?" Glimmer asks as they hit daylight. Adora draws to a halt, turning to look back over her shoulder at the pair. Compared to She-ra, they're small.

"Thaymor is the closest thing we have to a home, and I'm sworn to protect the planet. Now come on. We need to hurry," Adora tells

them, exchanging a look with Catra. They only need a moment to communicate the plan. The castle doors slam shut behind them just as Glimmer's cape clears the threshold and Catra tilts forward. She and Adora take off for the trees, running straight in the direction of Thaymor.

Catra's ears swivel back. By the time they have hit the tree line, she hears feet pounding behind them, the rebels running to follow.

"Who are *you*?" Adora asks over her shoulder. The humans trail behind, but Catra has spent over a year now training to keep up with She-ra and she runs by her side.

"Commander Glimmer," the princess huffs out as she runs. Interesting that her military title is how she wants to be known.

"Bow! Soldier in the rebellion and renowned tinkerer. Well, one day, anyway," Bow responds. Catra rolls her eyes, leaping over a fallen log and hearing an *oof* a moment later when Bow is forced to climb over it. A twinkling, further back and then closer, causes Catra to turn her head in time to see Glimmer materializes into place on the other side of the log. Ugh. Showoff.

"We can't run all the way to Thaymor," Bow pants out as he catches up. Adora inclines her head to the side, enough to look at Catra and side-eye the pair over her shoulder.

"We're almost there," she replies, her words punctuated by a distant boom up ahead. Catra's fur prickles.

"But- how? We were so far away," Bow asks. Catra snorts as she leaps up into a tree, squinting towards a gap in the branches. Smoke. Shit.

"The woods bend for She-ra. They take Adora wherever she needs to go," Catra replies, tone changing as she slips out of the quote from Light Hope and into her own voice. She jumps from the tree,

hitting the ground running and putting on an extra burst of speed to catch up with Adora as the trees begin to thin.

The conversation stops, because now they can see it's so much more than *smoke*.

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Adora's step falters when the trees part to show them Thaymor – or rather, the shell of it. Smoke rises in the air, darkening the scene as fires from laser blasts burn errantly with no one to control them. Homes feature gaping holes from cannon blasts and she can hear the citizens that haven't managed to flee yet screaming. Underscoring the destruction is the thudding of bots and tanks rolling over the village with no concern for the life within.

Adora's hand tightens on the hilt of her sword. If Light Hope had let her out the moment her sensors picked up the attack, some of this destruction might have been prevented, but instead she was so concerned with getting Catra to drive out the intruders first that she tried to hold Adora back. She wants She-ra to be ready for battle before they risk revealing her to the world, but how could they ever stand by and let this happen? They have to stop it, which means they have to reveal She-ra.

Adora has been training for years. This is it.

"Catra," she says, glancing to the side. Catra nods, receiving the message instantly. She runs to scale up one of the homes as Adora sets forward through the destruction.

"Southeast side!" Catra calls from on top of the house, already leaping to the next to get a better look at the movement around the village. Adora turns, taking off towards the center of the destruction.

Glimmer and Bow are following them, Glimmer disappearing in a burst of sparkles, but Adora isn't worrying about them right now. Stopping the Horde is her priority and it should be the same for Rebellion fighters.

"Festival square!" Catra calls again, off to Adora's left this time. Adora's heart picks up in her chest, but she forces her thoughts steady. She needs battle mode right now, not emotion. She needs to *stop* this.

She doesn't know how she can not be emotional when surrounded by the ruins of the one place where they found support and acceptance outside of each other.

Catra suddenly yells, a sound of fear that has Adora's head whipping up, but Catra has already leaped down to the ground, landing in a roll and springing to her feet by the time that the blast she fled from goes flying overhead. Adora's mouth sets into a grim line. She plants her feet and pushes off the ground, leaping into the air and clear over the building. She only gets milliseconds to process the square below filled with tanks and bots, villagers running for their lives. She whips her sword to the side, using the weight and added momentum to correct mid-air and land on top of one of the tanks.

Light Hope's schematics run through her head as she looks around for what could be an entry port, finding it a moment later and grabbing it. With She-ra's strength, she can rip it straight off its hinges. The Horde soldier inside screams into his helmet. The screaming gets louder and then much quieter when she grabs him by the shoulder and yanks him out of the tank, tossing him back without looking. His scream cuts off with a thud as he hits the side of a building and slides down it.

The noise draws attention. Adora looks up to find bots turning towards her and a tank cannon slowly rotating as a light revs in its barrel, preparing to shoot her. People are still fleeing from the square, looking back over their shoulders and gaping as they do. Adora needs to be the target until they can get to safety.

At seven feet and glowing, that isn't hard to do.

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Catra kicks a Horde soldier in the chest and sends him flying back into Glimmer, who punches him before he can knock her over. It's a clumsy lack of coordination with these strangers, but honestly it looks pretty cool and planned from the outside.

"Why are they targeting Thaymor? It's a small civilian settlement!" Bow asks as he shoots an arrow that deploys a fucking *net* and tangles another soldier up. A lizardfolk solider comes at Catra, too big for her to simply knock over, but she dodges under their hit and tags them in the side with the baton. They seize up and she brings the side of her fist down hard on their head, using the meat of her palm to cushion the impact on her hand as it sends them straight down into the dirt.

"It's the closest settlement to the edge of the woods. They've tried to breach them off and on for years. They probably think they can get a foothold here and branch out. Decades of war and they still have no idea how the woods work," Catra returns, scanning around and finding the coast momentarily clear. She leaps up the side of a hollowed-out building, scaling it to look down onto the chaos in the festival square.

"*No one* knows how the woods work!" Glimmer yells back, followed by the sound of sparkling that Catra recognizes as her magic now they have spent several minutes fighting together.

"Then you aren't listening to them!" Catra shoots back, her eyes scanning the destruction She-ra has left in her wake, a half dozen bots and tanks in pieces. The attacking force seems to have gotten the message there's a big player, all of them converging on the

square. Adora has been limited in what she could do by the fleeing civilians, but Catra is pretty sure they're all out now. Catra and the dynamic duo were holding a path open for them, but there's none in sight anymore. She watches a tank and five bots converge on the empty square below, Adora looking up from the bot she was eviscerating as they close in around her. The remaining Horde soldiers crest the edges of the square, all of them with their weapons ready and pointing at She-ra.

"Adora!" Catra calls. Adora turns her head, beaming blue making eye contact with Catra as Glimmer sparkles into existence on the roof beside Catra. Bow is already perched on the next one over.

"Civilians are clear!" Catra calls. Some of the Horde soldiers have turned to face her, but they won't have the opportunity to attack. Adora's eyes flare blue, permission granted. "Hold on tight," Catra mutters to her companions, already reaching down to bury her claws in the roof.

"What-" Glimmer starts to question, cutting off as Adora begins to glow gold, an aura of power surrounding her as she leaps – unnecessarily high, show off – into the air and lands with a small quake in the center of the town. Around her, the sounds of lasers priming and guns being readied echoes, but Adora doesn't react to any of them, calmly raising her sword in the air and flipping it point-down.

Catra's claws flex as Adora drives the sword down into the ground with the force of an earthquake, bearing all her weight down on it. Her hair and cape stream up around her as the entire village shakes, cracks radiating out from the sword. The ground upheaves beneath bots and tanks, sending them flying as soldiers scream, everyone scrambling for safety, but that's nowhere to hide when the ground itself is fighting you. The soldiers flee whenever they can get their feet under them.

Glimmer begins to slide down the roof beside Catra, scrambling to find purchase before the tremors shake her down into the danger

zone. Catra growls, flexing her right hand until her claws are buried so deep that her fingertips are digging into the house so she is anchored enough to rip her left hand free, grabbing Glimmer by the base of the cape as the ground continues to tremble.

"Retreat!" Catra hears called through a helmet speaker, similar sentiments echoed by several soldiers as they all scramble away from the easing tremors.

Slowly, Adora raises her head, making eye contact with Catra up on the roof. Her expression is still cool and in control, focused the same way it was the first time she turned into She-ra. Catra nods to her. Around her shoulders, Adora's hair falls along with her cape, gravity's influence returning to her. The tremors cease as the gold beaming from her fades, leaving just She-ra standing in the middle of the square, slowly standing and pulling her sword free from the ground.

She often looks ethereal, but compared to the power she just displayed, she looks unusually human even at seven feet tall.

"Whoa," Glimmer breathes. Catra smirks as she releases Glimmer's scruff, sliding her claws out from the roof and slowly standing. As jealous as she has been of Adora's power and stupid destiny at times, she feels proud watching her be a badass. Catra stands, gracefully leaping down to the ground as her ears swivel around to listen to the Horde forces retreat. In the middle of the clearing, she watches that stony concentration on Adora's face break with a smile.

Catra runs forward, leaping at Adora when she's close enough. Of course Adora catches her, easily supporting Catra as she climbs up her shoulders, wrapping around Adora's head in a sideways hug before she sits up to perch on her shoulder, better poised to listen.

"Did everyone get out?" Adora asks her, one arm crossed over her chest so Catra can brace off of it and the other reached up to steady her on her perch.

"Everyone still trying to when we arrived, at least. Glimmer and Bow helped me clear a path. They're alright," Catra responds, jerking her head towards where the pair is descending the slope of the hill. Adora chuckles, looking up at Catra with those wide blue eyes that make her feel way too many emotions. It doesn't help that Adora is carrying her effortlessly and just kicked ass.

Listen, Catra may be jealous, but she also can appreciate when the girl she's in love with turns into a goddess. She feels as much pride as yearning when she sees Adora demonstrate She-ra's power.

"Think the Horde's coming back?" Adora asks, her tone smug. Catra rolls her eyes.

"I'm not going to stroke your ego and tell you how cool you are," she returns, just before Glimmer and Bow reach them.

"That was so cool! Where'd you learn to do that?" Bow asks. Adora's face breaks into a smug grin, her eyes holding Catra's for a minute to gloat before she looks down to Bow.

"I've been training for years to fight the Horde," Adora replies. Catra's tail dances, curling over Adora's shoulders and "accidentally" hitting her in the face. Adora sputters as she bats it away. "*We've* been training," she corrects, looking up to make sure Catra sees how unimpressed she is. Catra smiles innocently down at her. She notices Adora's gaze catching on her teeth. Okay, it's not *her* fault no smile seems all that innocent to humans – or the human-adjacent – when there are fangs hiding in it.

"You're a princess, aren't you?" Glimmer asks. Adora smiles, turning her head back to Glimmer to nod. Catra rolls her eyes. Come on, that's obvious. Bracing herself, Catra carefully leaps down from Adora's shoulder and lands beside her, crossing her arms.

"Princess of Power," Catra parrots in Light Hope's cadence. Adora snickers, transforming her sword into a vambrace to free her hands. She closes her eyes and She-ra falls away, Adora shrinking down to

her regular height. t takes Catra a second to figure out why Glimmer and Bow even startle. She spends so much time with Adora, she forgot everyone doesnt just *know* she's underneath She-ra's glow. Adora seems unphased by their surprise, reaching her hand out as if to shake.

Im Adora. Ive been training in secret as She-ra for a long time, but the Horde knows Im here now . t' s time to take the fight to them. Youre a commander in the Rebellion, right?Adora asks. Glimmer nods, straightening up to her full height. She still isnt even as tall as Catra. Adora radiates excitement, glancing to Catra. She' s looking for permission, but whether or not Catra gives it, she's pretty sure Adora is going to steam on ahead. Catra rolls her eyes and waves her hand dismissively. t might as well be a ringing endorsement to Adora with the way she surges with confidence.

W e want to join the Rebellion and fight of f the Horde,"Adora says, holding her hand out like she expects Glimmer to induct her in right there.

Y ouve kind of seen our resume already ,"Catra drawls beside her , inspecting her claws and flashing Adora a grin that she immediately returns. Catra watches Glimmer out of the side of her eye as Glimmer exchanges a look with Bow and then nods, determined.

Ive been petitioning to restart the Princess Alliance. W ell gladly accept another princess into our ranks,"Glimmer agrees, taking Adora's hand and shaking it. Adora, the dork, pumps her free hand in the air and whoops, turning around to hug Catra and lift her up. Catra cant help laughing, wrapping her arms around Adora and letting her spin her around in the middle of a warzone.

W ere rebels!"Adora declares, joy painted across her face as she puts Catra back down and beams at her, hands still lingering on her waist. Catra's heart flutters, Adora's excitement infectious.

f only they didnt have an audience, because Catra is certainly having *thoughts*. Her heart wants what it always does, but she

contents herself with Adora's smile and the weight of her hands on her waist.

"The Horde has no idea what' s coming for them," Catra says, watching Adora beam and bob her head. Stars, she's so cute. t' s not fair Adora can go from effortlessly strong and cocky to this excited *dork*.

"Y eah, uh. What *is* coming for them?" Glimmer asks, glancing between them and then down at Adora's vambrace. What she has seen so far has likely only confused her. Catra and Adora exchange a look and then they both giggle.

"Long story . Let's get the village back in order first," Adora says. Catra nods, glancing up at the trails of smoke still in the air.

t' s their first taste of war, and she can already see it's about more than just fighting. She looks back down at the pair in front of them and feels a twist in her stomach. t would be so easy to say it' s just because of the destruction, but she tried to dismiss it as just the intrusion back in the castle, and it's more than that, even if that sucked too. Being discovered adds up to the same thing as the attack on Thaymor: Adora's destiny is starting.

They've just signed onto the Rebellion and they already have two more people they're fighting beside. Everything is going to be different and soon theyll be surrounded with new people. What if Adora forgets about her?

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Things would be a lot easier if any of them had some kind of water magic, but Salineas has closed itself off, so they're on their own. Luckily, none of the fires are burning out of control. They go around

the village stomping them out and checking for trapped citizens. Glimmer teleports two out to safety before they reach the edge of town and find some people filtering back in, a large group that Catra, Glimmer, and Bow apparently helped escape. The other citizens fled before they got there and likely are going to take longer before trying to come back, not knowing help ever arrived.

"I don't think the Horde is coming back. We put out all the fires, so you should be safe to return and start rebuilding," Adora assures the mayor. He has always been fairly neutral on her and Catra's existence in and around the village. Now he looks like he could cry looking between Adora and Glimmer. Catra and Bow are both helping the stragglers in the group, or Adora is sure he would extend his thanks to them too.

"Thank you, Adora. Thank you, Princess. All of you. We never thought they would attack out here. We weren't expecting any aid when they did, especially on a holiday," he tells them. Adora nods, dipping a little to turn it into a half-bow when Glimmer does some kind of fancy bow with her fist crossed over her chest. It might be a Rebellion thing, or it might be a royal thing. Adora has figured out who Glimmer is by now, but she hasn't wanted to say anything and make it obvious that she didn't realize until after the battle was done and her brain caught up with *Glimmer* and *teleporting*.

"Adora!" Catra's voice calls. Adora immediately whips around even though Catra's tone doesn't sound anxious. Catra is at the very back of the group, leaned over a boy sat on the ground with three people huddled around him. Adora frowns, setting over to them as Glimmer continues talking to the mayor, assuring him that Bright Moon will send what aid it can to the small community. Catra looks up as Adora approaches and Adora realizes she knows the boy.

Up close, she can see the scar on his arm as easily as she can see his leg is limp, currently wrapped in fabric with sticks stuck through the layers. An improvised splint, most likely.

"His leg is broken. It took three people to get him this far. Can you carry him back to the clinic?" Catra asks, gesturing down at him. He has always skirted around Catra since the last time they played together, the scar a stark reminder, but now he just looks exhausted.

"Satyrs are heavier than humans or magicats. One person can't take his weight. If we got a stretcher from the clinic, it would be easier," a woman from the huddle around him says. Adora is pretty sure she's part of his family, some kind of adult responsible in his life who yelled at them when she saw the blood. Adora shakes her head, stepping back and making sure she has a clear radius around her.

"I'm not just a human," she assures, stretching her arm out. The bracer around her arm transforms into gold light, warping into her hand and solidifying into the Sword of Protection. She watches eyes widen around her as the magic draws attention. Some of them saw She-ra in the festival square, but they weren't likely to have looked that long, and no one saw her transform. It didn't occur to her until now that no one had made the connection. Adora raises her sword to the air.

"For the honor of Grayskull!" she says, keeping her voice set at a moderate volume despite the command she infuses into it. People are already looking, but she doesn't want to frighten them. The gold overtakes her, her body growing, but she forces her power to flare, rushing through the transformation so all she has to do is toss her sword in the air, freeing her hand to pound one fist into her palm, sparking her accessories into life around her already-formed armor. She snatches the sword as it falls, her hair and cape settling back against her back. She looks down – much further down, now – to find the huddle gaping up at her.

"Can I take the sword?" Catra asks, her tone both bored and teasing. Adora looks to the right to send her a flat look. "What? You need your hands free," Catra says, voice falsely innocent and the waving of her tail giving her away. Catra's eyes suddenly widen and she scrambles to catch it as Adora tosses the sword her way. She manages to grab it without cutting herself though, quick reflexes only

hampered by her surprise. Adora turns back to the boy, squatting down beside him.

"Anything else hurt that I should watch out for?" Adora asks, making eye contact with him and hoping it will be enough to pull him out of his shock. Slowly, he closes his mouth, fallen open in surprise.

"My back hurts, but nothing else is broken," he says with a shaky voice. Adora nods, reaching down and doing her best to lift him without hurting him. He hisses in pain, but once she gets him settled in her arms and straightens up, he falls silent. Adora glances down at him, checking in, and he just nods, carefully raising an arm and throwing it around her shoulders for stability. Adora turns and the crowd, though still staring, parts for her.

No one tries to direct her and Catra to the clinic, letting them pass in a silence that feels as reverent as it is shell-shocked. No matter how different she looks, she's still Adora. She grew up here. She knows where to go even surrounded in wreckage.

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They're back in the festival square. Glimmer has mentioned reporting in at Bright Moon once or twice, but it's clear she wants Catra and Adora to come with her, so it will have to wait. They're close to being able to leave, more people filtering in to pick up the pieces, but She-ra's strength is useful for hauling decimated tanks and large chunks of buildings out of the way. A pile of wreckage is beginning in the center of the square, a convenient open space to gather it before they figure out how to break it down.

"Has she always been able to do that?" the mayor asks from Catra's right as they both watch She-ra carry a large chunk of tank

over her head towards the pile. To Catra's left, she notices both Glimmer and Bow turning to watch her answer. Catra shrugs.

"Kind of. She was born She-ra's reincarnation, but she has only been able to transform for a year or two. She's still learning all her powers," Catra explains. A citizen doesn't need more details than that. Ideally the Horde never finds out that Adora needs the sword to transform, but they also don't want people who already know the legend of She-ra to expect everything from Adora. She doesn't know if she can even heal yet. It's kind of hard to *practice* and it hasn't worked on either of them for the small sprains and cuts that Adora has tried it on so far.

"I guess I know why your guardian lets you run around the woods alone now," the mayor jokes lightly. There's a somber air to the village – they're all gathered around a pile of its wreckage, after all – but slowly, Catra can see spirits lifting again as people find their homes are – mostly – still livable, even if they'll be making repairs for a long time. The festival square itself needs to be refinished after the tank tacks and Adora's earthquake disrupted its topography.

"Yeah, she's been raising us to fight the Horde since we could hold a sword," Catra responds, distracted, as she watches Adora pause to listen to woman who has come up to her that Catra recognizes. Swiveling her ears, she can hear snatches of *wreckage… crib. We got out… nowhere to rest*. Adora's expression doesn't turn horrified, so the baby must be fine, but her face settles into a frown and she nods, letting the woman lead her away from the main square. Catra sighs, her shoulders falling.

"We were so little, it was obvious we couldn't fight yet, but then we had been training for so long it was hard to know when to stop," she explains, gaze roaming over the wreckage. Her ears droop as her heart beats unsteadily. "The Horde came to us. There's no more waiting. It's time to pay them back. They took our homes from us once. It's not happening again," she says. She turns towards the mayor, feeling the same determination she just saw on Adora's face set in her heart.

She might be terrified of where Adora's destiny will take them, but she's done hiding. She's done being told what to do by a hologram. She's done being *nobody*. There's only one way to earn the recognition she wants. She meets the mayor's eye, his expression as serious as hers, waiting to receive her oath.

"We're not going to let them keep doing this. She-ra is called the Princess of Power for a reason. We can make a difference. We're joining the Rebellion, but if the Horde ever comes back to try again, we will too," she promises.

She's always looked at the mayor and just seen *adult* and *authority figure*, but now she watches a measure of relief break in his eyes at her words. He reaches his arm out and Catra takes it, shaking firmly.

"After everything we've seen, I believe in you girls. The Rebellion needs strong fighters. We'll be okay. We'll rebuild, and when this is all done, we'll throw another festival," he promises her. Catra's heart constricts, lifting in her chest. She quirks a small smile.

"The Horde won't interrupt this one," she promises. He smiles too, nodding to her.

"I'll hold you to that," he agrees. It's not going to be easy, but Catra keeps her promises.

End Notes

Iswear Im not trying to make glimbow seem like scaredy-cats, this is just how they (and Adora) acted in the ghost episode (Signals) 😂 There was supposed to be more of them in this, but then Igot caught up in Catra and Adora' s backstory with the village and just had to explore more of that since it' s unique to this universe. Glimbow seeing them interact with the villagers also helps them trust them and build a relationship (since they didnt get a full day of bonding – even if it was under a lot more duress and suspicion – in this AU like they did in the pilot).

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